



SUSIE CHUNG teaches piano to Charlotte Huang, 5, in San Gabriel after her Altadena home studio burned down in January. CARLIN STEHL For The Times

A piece of Oscars history, lost

A treasured piano, played by Lady Gaga, is no more because of the Eaton fire

MARY McNAMARA



Six years ago, midway through the 91st Academy Awards telecast, a walnut Steinway & Sons Model B grand piano took center stage at the Dolby Theatre. After being smoothly propelled from the wings, it stood for a moment alone, its lid aglow with reflected top lights. Sharp-eyed movie fans might have recognized it as one of the pianos used in that year's Oscar-nominated "A Star Is Born" and indeed, Bradley Cooper and Lady Gaga quickly left their seats to perform the eventual original song winner, "Shallow." It was an emotional high point of the show, the camera circling the piano as Lady [See Piano, A9]



LADY GAGA and Bradley Cooper sing "Shallow" from "A Star Is Born" at the 2019 Academy Awards. Chung owned the Steinway piano featured in the performance. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

DEI ban leaves the state walking fine line

Schools and colleges seek to keep diversity efforts without raising Trump officials' ire.

By JAWEED KALEEM AND HOWARD BLUME

With educators facing a federal deadline to abolish race-specific programs or risk funding cuts, California public universities and schools are defending diversity efforts while carefully avoiding clashes with the Trump administration, prompting confusion over the future of traditions including culturally themed dorm floors, Black student graduation ceremonies and scholarships for Latinos. In a Feb. 14 letter, the U.S. Department of Education told all K-12 school districts and higher education institutions to end the use of race in "admissions, hiring, promotion, compensation, financial aid, scholarships, prizes, administrative support, discipline, housing, graduation ceremonies, and all other aspects of student, academic, and campus life." It laid out a new federal anti-discrimination enforcement policy, threatening to pull federal dollars from schools that do not fall in line. The response from many leaders of California universities and schools? Cautious and judiciously worded statements. So far, the state's public university systems have not ordered affinity clubs or programming to shut down. Culturally themed dorms still exist. Scholarships have not been rescinded. And, leaders said, they already adhere to California law that [See DEI, A6]

'I was lied to,' recovery chief says

Steve Soboroff vents at school event about lack of pay, later walks back his comments.

By JULIA WICK AND DAVID ZAHNISER

Steve Soboroff, Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass' wildfire recovery czar, went public with his frustrations about doing the job for free, telling an audience he was "lied to" — and had the texts and emails to back it up. The remarks, made to an alumni group at Harvard-Westlake School last week, came as Soboroff attempted to address what he called "the elephant in the room": the city's initial plan to pay him \$500,000 over 90 days, and his subsequent decision to work without pay after an outcry over the size of his compensation. Soboroff, a real estate developer and civic leader who was selected by the mayor to do the work in mid-January, told reporters early on that [See Soboroff, A6]

Wildfires are burning deeper into urban areas

By SUMMER LIN AND TERRY CASTLEMAN

As California struggles to defend itself against increasingly destructive urban wildfires, recent fire deaths in Altadena highlight what researchers say is a growing trend in victim demographics. Up until about the last decade, California wildfires traditionally have affected higher-income white households, with deaths skewing toward seniors and men. More recently, however, wildfires are increasingly touching more diverse communities as fires grow in intensity and extend into densely populated areas, according to researchers. Of the 17 people killed by the Eaton fire, more than 70% were Black and 64% were women. More typically, however, those killed by the fire had a median age of 77 and at least a third of them suffered impairments that could affect their mobility, according to a Times analysis.

As in western Altadena, blazes are increasingly affecting more diverse communities



OF THE 17 people killed by the Eaton fire, more than 70% were Black and 64% were women. Above, a makeshift memorial in Pasadena last month to the victims. GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

A 2023 study of California wildfires conducted by U.S. Forest Service researchers found that "new fire regimes are increasingly affecting more urban census tracts statewide, meaning greater numbers and more diverse groups of people are being and possibly will be affected by wildfires." These changes, authors wrote, meant that more Latino, Asian and Black Californians were being impacted by wildfire than ever before. The trend, they say, could become even more pronounced in the future and potentially have serious consequences for wildfire readiness. "The increasing occurrence of wildfires in urban areas suggests a need for increased outreach to residents of more urbanized neighborhoods and communities that have never experienced wildfires," the study's authors wrote. "Even in those that have historically been sporadically affected by wildfire, their residents are likely to [See Wildfire, A7]

Federal tech workers resign

U.S. Digital Service staffers quit in protest of Elon Musk team's tactics. **NATION, A5**

Cleanup sends homeless packing

Home-like structure is among those destroyed along Arroyo Seco and the 110. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

State Farm tallies fire costs

Reinsurance will slash its \$7.6-billion total to about \$600 million, firm says. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 84/60. **B6**
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